The Struggle for This or That

A grammar of shares, rules, founders, and the shape of human conflict

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Every Sunday evening, somewhere, a family has the same argument. The weekend is nearly gone. One person wants to see friends; another wants to rest; a third wants to finish a project that has been waiting for weeks. Nobody is being unreasonable. Nobody wants to hurt anybody. And yet the evening cannot be spent three ways. The hours are few. The desires are many. The argument is not about who loves whom. It is about how a scarce thing—time—will be divided.

Now move to a different room. A company's leadership meets to allocate next year's budget. Three divisions want the same capital. Each has a case. Each case is partly true. The money is finite. The meeting is tense.

Now move to a different scale. A country's legislature fights over a budget. Parties, regions, and factions each claim a share of what the state can spend. The fight is loud, procedural, and old.

These scenes feel different. They differ in scale, in stakes, in the language used. But they have the same skeleton. In each, people are making claims on a share of something scarce. In each, the claims contend: satisfying one makes satisfying another harder. In each, the contention produces struggle—effort, argument, maneuvering, sometimes open conflict. And in each, rules determine who ends up with what.

That skeleton—share, claim, contention, struggle, rules—is the subject of this essay. But it is not the whole of it. Behind every set of rules is a foundation: the settlement that no prior rule settles. Behind every foundation is a founder: the person, group, or process that laid it. And beneath the foundation—so often unspoken—is a rigging: the initial advantage that the founding confers on some over others, an advantage that tends to preserve itself. This is the deepest layer, and it is the layer most people never see.

The whole picture is a grammar that many situations obey. It is not a theory of everything. But it changes what you notice. And it turns out to explain the oldest axis in politics—left and right—as well as the other axes that cut across it.

Key idea. A game is a struggle over shares, under rules, where what each player gets depends on what everyone claims—and the deepest layer, usually unseen, is the founder advantage underneath the rules.

The four words

Share

A share is the portion of something valuable that someone receives, keeps, or controls. It is what we also call a reward, a portion, a stake—what someone gets. A wage is a share of a firm's revenue. A child's hour of screen time is a share of the household's attention. A country's territory is a share of the earth. A grade is a share of the credit a course offers. A seat on a committee is a share of authority. A share need not be money. It can be time, attention, status, legitimacy, information, safety, or the chance to be heard.

Claim

A claim is what a person asserts, demands, proposes, or tries in order to obtain, keep, or enlarge a share. A bid is a claim on a good. A move in chess is a claim on a square. A budget request is a claim on funds. A knock on someone's door is a claim on their attention. A legal filing is a claim on a court's time. Claims can be compatible—two people can both get what they ask for. They can be incompatible—only one can win. Or they can be partly compatible,

so that satisfying one reduces but does not eliminate another.

Contention

Contention is the pivotal idea, and it is easy to miss because the word sounds like fighting. But contention is not yet a fight. It is the condition in which two or more claims bear on the same share, so that satisfying one affects the satisfaction of another. Contention is the situation that makes a fight possible. It is structural, not behavioral. A quiet office where two people want the same promotion is full of contention even if no one has said a word. A market where three firms compete for the same customers is full of contention even on days when nothing happens.

Rival, cooperative, coordinative

Contention comes in flavors. Some is rival: one person's share grows at another's expense. The promotion, the budget line, the single parking space—these are rival. Some is cooperative: each person's share grows when the other's does. Two colleagues building a practice together, two countries trading, two people raising a child—these are cooperative. Each prefers the other to do well. And some is coordinative: both parties want to agree on a joint arrangement, but neither cares much about the other's share per se—they only care that the arrangement be shared. Two drivers want to be on the same side of the road; which side matters far less than that both agree.

This three-way distinction is not academic. It is the difference between a marriage and a merger, between an alliance and a rivalry, between a standard and a contest. Most human relationships contain all three at once, in different proportions, over different things. A friendship is cooperative over affection, rival over scarce time, and coordinative over where to eat. Recognizing which is which is the beginning of strategy.

Struggle

A struggle is the activity of contending—the effort, time, risk, and resources people expend trying to secure, defend, or enlarge a share. Contention is the structure; struggle is the process.

A union negotiating a contract is struggling. A firm cutting prices is struggling. A person resisting the pull of their phone to finish a piece of work is struggling. A country in a cold war is struggling. A child learning to share is struggling, in a small way, with a large lesson.

Struggle has a grammar, and the grammar is revealing. English—and many other languages—let us say three things:

- We struggle for something: independence, market share, a place in the life we want.
- We struggle with someone against a common obstacle: our shared struggle for recognition, for justice, for survival.
- We struggle over something: the terms of a contract, the rules of an institution, the direction of a movement.

These three prepositions are not accidents of speech. They map directly onto the three kinds of contention. Struggle for is rival contention: I want the share, and if I get it you may not. Struggle with is cooperative contention: we want the share together, and our efforts reinforce. Struggle over is coordinative contention: we agree the thing matters, and we disagree on which arrangement to adopt. The grammar of struggle encodes the structure of contention. When you hear someone say "the struggle over the rules," you are listening to people who understand, perhaps without knowing it, that the deepest conflicts are not about shares but about the arrangements that determine shares.

> **Key idea.** Contention is the structure; struggle is the process. Struggle *for*, *with*, and *over* trace rival, cooperative, and coordinative contention.

Rules: the fifth word, and the deepest

That brings us to the fifth word, the one that often decides everything: rules.

What rules are

Rules are the arrangements that determine how claims become shares. They include the formal—contracts, laws, constitutions, auctions, voting systems—and the informal—norms, conventions, expectations, habits. A market's price mechanism is a rule. A firm's budgeting process is a rule. A family's unspoken understanding about who handles bedtime is a rule. A constitution is a rule of rules.

Rules shape the struggle

Rules matter because they determine which struggles take place and how shares are assigned once claims are made. Change the rule and you change the struggle. A promotion decided by seniority produces a different contest than one decided by performance review, which produces a different contest than one decided by a coin flip. None of these rules is neutral. Each favors some claimants and disadvantages others. Each produces its own kind of effort, its own kind of resentment, its own kind of peace.

Struggle over the rules

And so we arrive at the deepest form of contention, the one that runs beneath all the others: struggle over the rules. When people fight over a budget, they are fighting within the rules. When they fight over how the budget is decided— who sits on the committee, what the voting threshold is, what counts as a valid claim—they are fighting over the rules themselves. This is the struggle that shapes all subsequent struggles. It is why constitutional politics is more consequential than ordinary politics, why procedural reform in a legislature can matter more than any single bill, why a change in a firm's governance can matter more than a year of quarterly results.

Three questions to ask

A useful habit of mind follows from this. When you encounter a conflict, ask two questions in order. First: what is the share being contended? Second: what are the rules that determine who gets it? The first question is what most people ask. The second is what strategists ask. And a third question, rarer still: who decided the rules, and how?

> **Key idea.** Change the rule and you change the struggle. The deepest conflicts are over the rules, not the shares.

Who decided the rules?

The problem of first allocation

There is a question that follows immediately from the last section, and it is the question the framework cannot answer. If rules determine how claims become shares, then who decided the rules?

And who decided who decides?

This is the problem of first allocation. It is the problem of the allocation that no prior rule allocates—the allocation of rule-making authority itself. Every order has one, and none can justify it by its own rules.

The regress stops at the foundation

The regress is simple. If the rules were chosen under some rule, then that rule was chosen under another, and so on. Either the chain goes on forever—rules all the way down, with nothing at the bottom—or it stops somewhere. It stops at the foundation of the order: the settlement that is not itself settled by any prior rule. A constitution is a foundation. A company's charter is a foundation. A marriage is a foundation. The conditions you were born into are a foundation. Each is the bottom of its own order, the place where the regress of rules runs out.

The founder

The foundation is laid by a founder—the one who establishes the first rules. The founder may be a person: a conqueror, a constitution-writer, an entrepreneur, a parent. It may be a group: a constituent assembly, a founding partnership, a household. It may be a process: a community

gradually converging on a practice. Or it may be no one at all: history, drift, accident. The founder is the answer to who decided. The mode of founding is the answer to how.

Four ways a foundation is laid

There are four ways a foundation can be laid.

- **Force.** The founder imposes the rules. A revolution, a coup, a conquest, a founder's fiat. The rules are established by whoever can establish them.
- **Agreement.** The founders consent to the rules. A constitution, a charter, a compact, a marriage vow. The rules are established by those who will live under them, actually or in principle.
- **Convention.** The rules emerge from practice. No one decides; people follow a pattern, and the pattern hardens into a rule. Common law, industry custom, family tradition. The rules are established by no one in particular, over time.
- **Accident.** The rules are the residue of history. Path dependence, inheritance, drift. The rules are established by circumstance, not by anyone's choice.

The legitimacy deficit

Each of these is a way of founding an order. None of them is fully legitimate by the standards of the order it founds. Force is not legitimate. Agreement is hypothetical or incomplete. Convention is not chosen. Accident is not justified. This is not a reason for cynicism. It is a reason for clarity. It is why constitutions have founding myths, why firms have origin stories, why families have unspoken understandings about who decided what.

One problem, many names

The problem has many names in many fields. Philosophers call it original acquisition, or the state of nature, or the original position. Political theorists call it constituent power—the power that makes the constitution and is not made by it. Economists call it the initial endowment, and they often bracket it: the second welfare theorem says any efficient allocation is reachable from some endowment, but it does not say which endowment. Game theorists call it the disagreement point, and they take it as given. The name "first allocation" unifies all of these, because they are all the same problem in different registers.

> **Key idea.** Every order rests on a foundation—the settlement no prior rule settles—and no foundation justifies itself by its own rules.

Is the game rigged?

The rigged foundation

A foundation is not neutral. Whoever lays it lays it with their interests in mind—or with their interests encoded in the accidents of history that laid it. The first allocation is also an allocation

of advantage. We call this the rigged foundation: the initial advantage that the founding confers on some players over others.

Explicit and implicit advantage

The advantage can be explicit. A constitution that requires property ownership for the vote. A company charter that gives founders ten votes per share. An inheritance rule that favors one child over another. Or it can be implicit. First- mover advantages that compound over time. Information asymmetries between the founder and later players. The simple fact that the status quo is harder to change than it is to defend.

Self-reinforcement

A rigged foundation is usually self-reinforcing. The people it advantages are given—or can acquire—the procedural rights to block reforms that would reduce their advantage. A veto. A supermajority requirement. Agenda control. The rules that would allow reform are controlled by the people who would be reformed. This is why within-rules reform so often fails against a self-reinforcing rigging: not because the reformers lack arguments, but because the rules give the beneficiaries the power to say no.

Who struggles least

There is a corollary that is easy to miss. In a rigged order, the beneficiaries struggle less than the disadvantaged. The rules already favor them, so they have little to struggle for within the rules. The disadvantaged struggle constantly, because they must struggle not only against other claimants but against the rules themselves. This is why rigged orders often look calm on the surface: the people doing the struggling are the people whose struggles are least visible. The noise of politics is not a measure of contention; it is a measure of who is contending actively, and the beneficiaries of a rigged foundation are usually quiet.

Erosion

This does not mean the advantage is permanent. The beneficiary coalition can fragment. New players can accumulate the resources the rules depend on—capital, votes, information, labor, legitimacy. The rules can be reinterpreted by later readers in ways the founder never anticipated. A rigged foundation erodes, given enough time and enough change. But erosion is slow, uncertain, and often blocked precisely by the self-reinforcing mechanisms. So the practical claim stands: within-rules reform usually fails against a self-reinforcing rigging, and this is why de-rigging, when it happens, tends to happen by refounding rather than reform.

> **Key idea.** A rigged foundation is self-reinforcing: the beneficiaries hold the procedural rights to block reform.

The game is never zero-sum

What zero-sum means

Zero-sum means: what I gain, you lose, and nothing else changes. It is the logic of a fixed pie. A negotiation over the price of a house. A tennis match. A budget that has already been set.

The founder advantage is not a slice

But a game with a live founder advantage can never be purely zero-sum. Here is why.

A founder advantage is not a slice of the pie. It is a feature of how the pie is cut and how big it is. The founder did not win the game; the founder laid the field. And laying the field is not a move in the game—it is the condition of the game.

Two levels

This means the game has two levels. At the first level, players play within the rules. That level can be zero-sum: a fixed budget, a fixed market, a fixed amount of attention. At the second level, players struggle over the rules themselves. That level is never zero-sum, because the rules determine the size of the pie, not just its division.

The meta-game

The founder advantage is the trace of the second level in the first. It is evidence that the rules were laid by someone, in some mode, in someone's favor. And the existence of that someone—the founder—means the game has a meta- game.

Why zero-sum thinking fails

This is why zero-sum thinking is so often a mistake. It is the thinking of players who take the foundation for granted. It is not always wrong—sometimes you really are playing a fixed game, and you should fight for your slice. But the most important games are not fixed. They are laid, and they can be laid differently.

Who benefits from zero-sum framing

It is also why the people most insistent that the game is zero-sum are often the people who benefit from the current foundation. Zero-sum framing keeps the conversation inside the rules. It prevents the question of the foundation from being asked. "There is only so much to go around" is sometimes true and sometimes a way of saying "do not ask who decided how much goes around."

The slogan

A useful slogan: zero-sum is the arithmetic of players who cannot see the foundation. The framework's insistence on the first allocation is, in part, an insistence that the arithmetic is usually incomplete.

> **Key idea.** Zero-sum is the arithmetic of players who cannot see the foundation.

Can the rigging be undone?

Four paths

The framework identifies four ways the rigging can be undone, and each has its own costs.

- **Erosion.** The beneficiary coalition fragments. New players accumulate countervailing leverage. The rules are reinterpreted by later readers. Slowly, without anyone deciding to do so, the advantage declines. Erosion is the least dramatic path and often the most effective. It is also the least reliable: it depends on circumstances no one controls.

- **Within-rules reform.** The beneficiaries can be persuaded—by argument, by coalition pressure, by the desire for legitimacy—to accept reforms that reduce their advantage. This is the path the framework predicts will usually fail against a self-reinforcing rigging, and history bears the prediction out. But it can succeed when the beneficiary coalition is weak, divided, or dependent on legitimacy it cannot afford to lose. It is always worth trying, and it is rarely sufficient.

- **Refounding.** The foundation is replaced. A constitutional convention. A revolution. A company recapitalization. A family conversation that changes the terms. The advantage is removed, but the removal is not rule-governed—it is a new founding, with its own founders, its own mode, and its own legitimacy deficit. This is the deepest and the most dangerous path. It can create a better foundation or a worse one, and the uncertainty about which is why refoundings are so contested.

- **Anti-rigging.** The foundation is not merely replaced but redesigned so that future rigging is harder. Sunset clauses. Rotation in office. Transparency. Constitutional provisions that make re-rigging costly. This is the only durable path—because refounding without anti-rigging merely resets the board for the next founder. The revolution that de-rigs but does not anti-rig will produce a new rigging within a generation, often sooner. The question facing any de-rigging coalition is therefore not only whose advantage should be removed but what structure should make the next advantage harder to lay.

What this says about revolution

This is the most interesting thing the framework has to say about revolution. It explains revolutions: they are the de- rigging mechanism of last resort, when within-rules reform is blocked and erosion is too slow. It does not justify any particular revolution, for two reasons. First, every refounding carries its own legitimacy deficit—it cannot be justified by the standards it establishes, because those standards are what it is establishing. Second, every refounding risks re- rigging: many revolutions install a new elite with the same structural protections as the old one, and the framework predicts the new rigging will be exactly as persistent. A revolution that swaps beneficiaries without changing the structure of rigging has not de-rigged the order. It has re-rigged it.

The diagnostic and the normative limit

So the framework gives you the diagnostic for when a revolution is structurally necessary—rigging is self-reinforcing, within-rules reform is blocked, erosion is too slow—but not the normative

criterion for when it is justified. That requires a theory of justice the framework does not supply. The framework tells you when the question is forced; it does not tell you the answer.

> **Key idea.** Refounding without anti-rigging merely resets the board: the only durable path is to make the next rigging harder to lay.

Left and right

The framework explains the oldest axis in politics.

One structural question

In CSA terms, the left and the right are two responses to the same structural question: what is the relationship between the game within the rules and the game over the rules?

The left treats the over-rules game as primary. The foundation is where the action is, because the foundation determines the shares. If the foundation is rigged, playing well within the rules cannot help the disadvantaged. Politics must address the foundation.

The right treats the within-rules game as primary. The foundation provides the conditions for the game to exist. Without a stable foundation, there is no game at all. Politics must preserve the foundation and play well within it.

This is not a disagreement about facts. It is a disagreement about which facts matter. And both are right, in the sense that both levels are real. They disagree about emphasis.

The de-riggers and the foundation-defenders

But the mapping is sharper than that. The left is the de-rigging coalition: it sees the foundation as rigged, emphasizes the legitimacy deficit, and is sympathetic to refounding. The right is the foundation-defending coalition: it sees the foundation as legitimate (or at least established), emphasizes the coordination value of the rules, and is suspicious of refounding. The axis between them is the trace, in political space, of the contention structure.

The zero-sum disagreement as a move

The zero-sum disagreement is itself a strategic move. The left wants to say the advantage is live—contestable—

because that opens the over-rules game. The right wants to say the advantage is fixed—not contestable—because that closes the over-rules game and keeps the action within the rules. The disagreement about whether the game is zero-sum is not a disagreement about arithmetic. It is a disagreement about whether the foundation can be contested. And that disagreement is itself a move in the over-rules game.

The mapping is not perfect. Not everyone on the left is disadvantaged, and not everyone on the right is a beneficiary. A person can be a beneficiary of one rigging and disadvantaged by another. A populist right can be de-rigging (against elites) while a reformist left can be foundation-defending (defending the welfare state). The axis is a composite of several structural positions, and the composite is stable because the positions tend to correlate. But the correlation is not identity.

Why the axis persists

Why did this axis emerge, and why has it persisted? The terms come from the French Revolution, when the National Assembly seated supporters of the king on the right and supporters of the revolution on the left. That was exactly the de-rigging vs. foundation-defending axis: the right defended the ancien régime's foundation, the left wanted to replace it. The framework explains why this particular axis emerged—it is the trace of the contention structure—and why it has persisted through every subsequent realignment. The issues change because the specific riggings change. The axis persists because the structural question persists.

The synthesis and the limit

What does the framework say about the debate? It says that both positions have a structural basis. The left is right that foundations are often rigged. The right is right that refounding is dangerous and can re-rig. The synthesis is anti- rigging: change the structure so that future rigging is harder. This is neither purely left nor purely right. It is a structural design question.

And it says that the framework cannot adjudicate the normative question: how much rigging is acceptable, given the costs of de-rigging? That requires a theory of justice the framework does not supply. The framework tells you when the question is forced. It does not tell you the answer.

Two halves of one insight

The left and right are not enemies. They are two halves of a single structural insight. The left sees the foundation. The right sees the game. The framework sees both, and shows why neither can be reduced to the other.

> **Key idea.** Left and right are two halves of one structural insight: the left sees the foundation; the right sees the game. The framework sees both.

All the axes

The left-right axis is not the only axis in politics. It is the oldest and the most stable, but it is one of many. The framework explains why there are many, and why they take the shapes they do.

The five families

The space of political axes is the space of contestable parameters of the allocation problem. Every axis is a disagreement about one of five things: what is being divided, who is in the game, how much the rules cover, whether the founding is justified, or how the order should change. These five families generate all the major axes we observe.

Object axes

Object axes are about what is divided. The economic left-right axis is the paradigmatic case: the left wants to de-rig the economic foundation, the right wants to defend it. The materialist-postmaterialist axis is about which shares matter: as material shares become secure, the resource

set expands to identity, autonomy, and recognition. The green-growth axis extends the resource set even further, to environmental goods and future generations. The green axis is special because it brings in players who cannot contest—future generations and non-human nature—which is why it requires trustees, people who speak for the voiceless.

Boundary axes

Boundary axes are about who is in the game. The globalist-nationalist axis is a disagreement about membership: is the foundation for citizens, or for all affected parties? Expanding membership is structurally a refounding, because the foundation was laid for a smaller set—which is why the axis is so bitter. It is not a debate within the rules; it is a debate about who the rules are for. The hawk-dove axis is about whether other states are rival or cooperative contenders, and here the framework's nonzero-sum theorem applies directly: if the international foundation is live, doves are right; if it is fixed, hawks may be. The urban-rural and young-old axes are not disagreements about a parameter but structural positions: different players, with different resources and different relationships to the foundation.

Rule-scope axes

Rule-scope axes are about how much is governed by rules. The libertarian-authoritarian axis is a disagreement about the domain of the allocation: should it be minimal, leaving most claims to private allocation, or thick, covering most of life with collective rules? The federal-unitary axis is about the level at which rules are made. Both answer to the decomposition theorem: decentralization adds value when issues are separable, centralization when they are coupled.

Foundation-legitimacy axes

Foundation-legitimacy axes are about whether the founding is justified. The progressive-conservative axis is structurally identical to economic left-right, but over cultural shares: the progressive sees the cultural foundation as rigged and wants to refound it; the conservative sees it as established and wants to preserve it. This is why the two axes correlate—they are the same structure over different shares. The populist-elitist axis is a re-rigging axis: the populist claims the foundation has been captured by a new elite; the elitist defends the current coalition. The framework predicts that populist refoundings will re-rig rather than anti-rig, because populism is a de-rigging movement without an anti-rigging program. The religious-secular axis is the most structurally distinctive: it is a disagreement about the mode of founding, but a special one, because the religious view treats the founding as outside the four modes—as divine ordination rather than force, agreement, convention, or accident. The framework cannot adjudicate, because it has no category for transcendent authority. It can only note that the religious view refuses the regress, while the secular view lives with it.

Method axes

Method axes are about how to change. Reform-revolution is a disagreement about whether the rigging is self- reinforcing: if it is, reform is blocked and refounding is the only path; if it is not, reform is sufficient and refounding is dangerous. Moderate-radical is a disagreement about the coupling of issues: moderate when issues are separable, radical when they are coupled.

Why the axes correlate

Why do the axes correlate? Because the layers correlate. The beneficiaries of a rigged economic foundation tend to defend the cultural foundation, to prefer the within-rules game, and to see the founding as legitimate. But the correlation is not identity. A person can be economically left and culturally conservative, or vice versa. The composite is stable because the positions tend to correlate, not because they are identical.

Three predictions

What does the framework predict? Three things.

First, new axes will emerge as new resources become scarce. As data, attention, and identity become scarce, new object axes emerge around them. The framework predicts these will fit the same structural pattern: de-rigging vs. foundation-defending over the new resource.

Second, foundation-legitimacy axes will intensify as the rigging becomes more visible. As inequality increases and the disadvantaged become more aware of the foundation, the foundation-legitimacy axes will become more salient relative to the object axes. The framework predicts the rise of "identity" and "post-material" politics not because material politics has ended but because the foundation has become more contested.

Third, method axes will become more salient as reform is blocked. As rigging becomes more self-reinforcing, reform- revolution and moderate-radical will become more salient. The framework predicts the rise of anti-system politics not because people are irrational but because the system is structurally blocked.

The framework does not tell you which axis is correct. It tells you what each axis is about. That is what a grammar can do, and it is enough.

Key idea. Every political axis is a disagreement about one of five things: what is divided, who plays, how much the rules cover, whether the founding is justified, or how change happens.

Contention is not the same as difficulty

Having seen the deepest contention—the struggle over rules and their founding—let us step back and ask a more basic question: how does contention actually work, and where does it live?

Most of us assume that a situation is hard in proportion to how many people are involved. A solo decision is easy; a group decision is hard; a crowded room is harder still. This is false, and the framework shows why.

One person, intense contention

A single person can face a problem of intense contention. Consider someone deciding how to spend the next decade of their life. The resources are time, attention, energy, and the one body they have. The claims are a career, a relationship, a craft, a cause, a family, a rest. These claims contend. The person cannot have all of them in full. The contention is real, rival, and consequential, even though there is only one person in the room. The struggle is not against anyone. It is the struggle of a single life trying to allocate itself.

Many people, shallow contention

Conversely, a situation with millions of people can be almost entirely coordinative, and therefore not strategically difficult in the usual sense. Two hundred million drivers on a road network are not fighting each other. They are following a convention. The contention is enormous in scale and shallow in depth. Nobody is trying to take anyone's share. They are trying to agree, and they mostly succeed.

The contention map

So the real question is not how many people are involved. It is what is the pattern of contention. This pattern has a

shape, and the shape can be drawn. Imagine a network with each person as a dot. Draw an edge between two people when they rival-contend over some resource; draw a different edge when they cooperative-contend; draw a third when they coordinate. What you get is a map of the situation. Some regions of the map are dense with rivalry. Some are dense with cooperation. Some are sparse. Some are silent.

Difficulty is localized

That map is what actually determines how hard a situation is. Strategic difficulty is not spread evenly. It lives in the connected clusters of active contention. Everything outside those clusters is something else—a decision problem, a coordination problem, a matter of taste. A firm with fifty divisions may have strategic contention in only three of them; the other forty-seven are run by routine. A country with a hundred policy domains may have genuine political struggle in a handful; the rest are administered. A person with a dozen goals may have real contention among three; the other nine are compatible or irrelevant.

This is the single most useful consequence of the framework: strategic difficulty is localized. If you want to understand a situation, do not survey everything. Find the active clusters. Ask what is being contended, by whom, under what rules, and how hard people are struggling. Most of the noise is elsewhere.

> **Key idea.** Strategic difficulty is localized: find the active clusters of contention, and most of the noise is elsewhere.

Struggle costs something

The framework also reminds us of something easy to forget: struggle costs.

Struggle is an allocation

To struggle is to expend effort, and effort is finite. A person has only so much attention to spend on conflict. A firm has only so much managerial energy, legal budget, and political capital. A country has only so much public patience. This means that struggle is itself an allocation problem. You cannot struggle everywhere, so you must choose where to struggle—and where to concede.

The portfolio view

Most people do not think of their conflicts this way. They experience each fight as a fight, and each one seems to demand full commitment. But a strategist sees a portfolio. Some struggles are worth the cost. Some are not. Some are worth fighting with someone against a shared obstacle. Some are worth fighting over the rules of the game itself. Some are worth conceding early, to preserve effort for the fights that matter.

The diagnostic question

This is why the framework is not merely descriptive. It is diagnostic. When you feel overwhelmed by conflict—at work, at home, in public life—the useful question is not "how do I win all of these?" It is "which of these are the real ones?" The active struggle network is almost always smaller than the noise suggests. Conceding the periphery to concentrate on the center is not weakness. It is allocation.

> **Key idea.** Struggle is itself an allocation: concede the periphery to concentrate on the centre.

The three arenas

The framework's reach is wide because its vocabulary is the vocabulary of ordinary life. Three arenas show this clearly.

Personal life

A person allocating time across work, health, relationships, learning, and rest is solving a problem with one player and many claims. The shares are hours, attention, and energy. The claims are the demands of each part of life. The contention is often intense, even though it involves a single person. The struggle is the daily effort of resisting distraction, keeping commitments, and choosing what to let go.

The framework's advice here is precise. Goals that rival-contend for the same resource—deep work and social media both claiming the same attention, for instance—will not be resolved by willpower alone. They require a rule: a commitment device, a schedule, a friction, a boundary. Willpower is a resource, and it depletes; rules do not. Goals that are cooperative or coordinative—exercise and sleep, a morning routine, a shared household rhythm—require not willpower but alignment. They are not struggles at all, once arranged.

This is a genuinely different way of thinking about self-control. Instead of asking "how do I become stronger?" it asks "what rule would make this easy?" The second question is often answerable. The first is often not.

And there is a deeper version of the same point. The conditions you were born into—your family, your country, your body, your era—are the foundation of your personal order. You did not lay them. They are rigged in your favor in some

ways and against you in others, and the rigging tracks nothing you did. Recognizing this is not a counsel of resentment. It is a counsel of realism. You can work within the foundation, and occasionally, at great cost, refound some small part of it. You cannot pretend the foundation is not there.

Politics

Political life is contention in its most visible form. Shares include budget, authority, legitimacy, agenda control, and votes. Claims are made by voters, parties, bureaucracies, interest groups, and courts. Struggles take the form of campaigns, lobbying, litigation, and protest. Rules include constitutions, electoral systems, legislative procedure, and federalism.

The framework's first insight is that rule contention is meta-contention. The most consequential political struggles are not over a single allocation but over the rules that determine all allocations. Constitutional design, districting, procedural reform—these are contests over the shape of future contests. They are deeper than ordinary politics because they set the terms on which ordinary politics will be played.

The second insight is that coalitions are cooperative contention. Parties that agree on goals but disagree on shares form coalitions that are stable only when the agreement is credible. The stability of a coalition is not a matter of sentiment; it is a matter of whether each member would rather stay than leave. This is why coalitions break—not because people stop liking each other, but because the terms of cooperation stop being worth it to someone.

The third insight is that decomposition localizes conflict. Many political fights are strategically separable: what happens in one policy domain does not much affect another. The contention map shows which domains are genuinely coupled and which are artificially bundled. This is useful both for reformers, who can often make progress by unbundling, and for defenders, who can often protect a position by keeping it bundled with something popular.

The fourth insight is that the deepest struggle is over the foundation, and the foundation may be rigged. Beneath rule contention lies contention over who founds the rules. When the foundation is rigged—malapportionment, gerrymandering, entrenchment of particular interests—the disadvantaged contest the foundation itself, and the beneficiaries defend it. The rules that would resolve the contest are the very rules in dispute.

And the fifth insight is that revolution is the de-rigging mechanism of last resort. When rigging is self-reinforcing and within-rules reform is blocked, refounding is the only remaining path. The framework explains revolutions as structurally necessary under these conditions. It does not justify any particular revolution, because every refounding carries its own legitimacy deficit and risks re-rigging. The normative question requires a theory of justice that the framework does not supply.

Business

A firm allocates capital, capacity, talent, data, and attention across markets and functions, while rivals, suppliers, and regulators do the same. Shares include market share, margin, talent, data, and customer attention. Claims are investments, hires, prices, product moves. Rules include contracts, auctions, market structure, and regulation. Struggles are price competition, advertising spend, litigation, and lobbying.

The framework's first strategic question for a business is: which resources are rival-contended? Rivalry over customer attention, talent, and capacity produces different dynamics than cooperation over complementary assets. A firm that mistakes a cooperative relationship for a rivalry, or a rivalry for a coordination problem, will misallocate its effort. The contention map tells you which game you are in.

The second question is: what is the allocation mapping? Strategy is often the design of the

rules, not just the choice of moves within them. Platform rules, pricing mechanisms, supply contracts—these are the firm's way of shaping how claims become shares. The firm that designs the game it plays has an advantage over the firm that merely plays well.

The third question is: when does strategy decompose? Multi-business firms can often be decomposed into strategically separable units. Central coordination adds value when contention is coupled—when decisions in one unit genuinely affect another. It adds only overhead when contention is separable. Knowing which is which is the difference between a focused firm and a conglomerate that has mistaken its own complexity for strategy.

The fourth question is: what is the founding, and is it rigged? The incorporation—the charter, the cap table, the governance—is the first allocation of the firm. Founder shares, dual-class stock, board composition, and anti-takeover provisions are devices that encode the founder's advantage into the corporate constitution. Founder disputes are bitter because they are about the foundation, not about ordinary management. Governance reforms are contested for the

same reason, and they often fail because the rigged foundation gives the beneficiaries the procedural rights to block de-rigging. "Who decides" is a deeper question than "what is decided," and "who decided the founding" is deeper still.

The fifth question is: is the competitive game zero-sum? Rarely. A firm that mistakes a live founder advantage for a fixed pie—its own or a rival's—will misread the strategic situation. Markets are rival at the margin but nonzero-sum over their foundations: regulation, standards, market structure, and technology shift the total, not merely its division. A firm that invests in shaping these foundations is playing the over-rules game; one that only optimizes within them is playing the within-rules game. Both can be correct, but confusing the two is a strategic error.

> **Key idea.** Whether in personal life, politics, or business, the moves are the same: name the share, map the contention, look at the rules, look at the foundation.

The honest limits

It would be dishonest to present this framework as a theory of everything, and the honest version is more useful anyway.

A lens, not a law

First, the framework is a lens, not a law. It does not tell you what will happen. It tells you what to look at. The same situation can be described as a struggle over shares, a coordination problem, a signaling game, or a matter of taste, and the right description depends on the situation. The framework earns its keep when allocation and contention are the salient features—which is often, but not always.

Organizing, not explaining

Second, the framework does not explain human behavior. It organizes it. Why people want the shares they want, why they struggle as hard as they do, why they sometimes prefer conflict to settlement—these are questions for psychology, anthropology, and ethics. The framework tells you where to look; it does not tell you what you will find.

Descriptive, not normative

Third, the framework is descriptive, not normative. It can help you see that an allocation is inefficient or that a rule favors some claimants over others. It cannot tell you what a just allocation would be. That requires a theory of justice, which the framework can inform but cannot replace. The problem of first allocation sharpens this: the legitimacy deficit of every founding means that no purely procedural theory of justice can fully ground itself. Normative theory must confront the founding, not merely the rules that follow from it.

Bracketing the first allocation

Fourth, the framework brackets the first allocation. It takes the rules as given or chosen and derives allocations from them. It cannot tell you how the rules came to be, who founded them, whether the founding is legitimate, or how foundations change. This is a genuine limit, not a minor one. The legitimacy of any allocation depends on the legitimacy of the rules, and the legitimacy of the rules depends on the founding. A complete theory would need to say how first allocations are made, justified, and changed. The framework identifies where that theory is needed; it does not supply it.

Structural, not exhaustive

Fifth, the framework's account of political axes is structural, not exhaustive. It explains why the axes exist and what they are about. It does not explain why any particular person holds any particular view. That requires psychology, socialization, and interest, which the framework does not supply.

None of these limits is fatal. Every useful lens has them. What matters is whether the lens shows you something the naked eye misses. This one does.

> **Key idea.** The framework is a lens, not a law: it shows you what to look at, but it cannot supply a theory of justice.

What to do with it

Six habits

If the framework is useful, it should change how you look at the world. Six habits follow.

1. **Name the share.** When you encounter a conflict, ask what is actually being divided. It is often not what the participants say. A fight about money may be a fight about recognition. A fight about recognition may be a fight about time. Naming the share is the beginning of understanding.

2. **Map the contention.** Ask who is coupled with whom, and over what. Ask whether the coupling is rival, cooperative, or coordinative. Ask which clusters are active and which are latent. The map is usually smaller and clearer than the noise.

3. **Look at the rules.** Ask what determines how claims become shares. Ask who set the rules and why. Ask whether the rules are the real stakes. They often are.

4. **Look at the foundation.** Ask where the rules themselves came from. Ask who founded the order and in what mode—force, agreement, convention, or accident. Ask what legitimacy deficit the founding carries, and whether that deficit is still being paid. The foundation is the deepest layer, and it is the one most people never see.

5. **Ask whether the game is rigged.** Ask who benefits from the foundation. Ask whether the beneficiaries hold the procedural rights to block reform. Ask whether the advantage is self-reinforcing. Ask whether what looks like a fair competition is being played on a field that was tilted at the founding. This is the question that reframes every zero-sum argument you encounter, and it is the question that most people never ask.

6. **Count the cost.** Ask where your effort is best spent. Ask what you can concede to concentrate on what matters. Ask whether the struggle you are in is one you chose or one you fell into. Struggle is finite. Spend it where it counts.

These six habits are not a formula. They are a discipline. They will not tell you what to do. They will help you see what you are doing.

Key idea. Six habits—name the share, map the contention, look at the rules, look at the foundation, ask whether it is rigged, count the cost—turn the grammar into a discipline.

Coda

The family arguing about Sunday evening, the firm fighting over next year's budget, the legislature fighting over the shape of the state—these are not separate phenomena. They are variations on a single pattern. People make claims on shares. The claims contend. The contention produces struggle. The struggle is shaped by rules. The rules are laid by founders. The founders rest on foundations that no rule can fully justify. And the foundations are usually rigged, in favor of some and against others, in ways that persist.

This is not a counsel of cynicism. It is a counsel of clarity. To see that life is full of contention is not to see that life is only contention. Much of what makes life good—cooperation, coordination, love, craft, shared purpose—is not rival at all. The framework's point is not that everything is a fight. It is that fights have structure, and that structure can be seen. Once seen, it can be navigated. Once navigated, it can sometimes be transcended.

A game, in the end, is a struggle over shares, under rules, where what each player gets depends on what everyone claims. That sentence is not the whole of human life. But it is more of human life than we usually admit—and admitting it is the first step toward playing the game better, and, occasionally, toward changing it.

And the deepest change is not winning within the rules. It is laying new foundations—which is what every founder, every constitution, every fresh start has always been. The field can be relaid. But a relaying that does not change the terms of laying merely resets the board for the next founder. The question is not only whose advantage should be removed but what structure should make the next advantage harder to lay. The game is played on a field that someone laid, and the laying of the field is not itself a move in the game. But it is the most consequential thing that ever happens in it.

And when you stand on the field and ask why some are born with the wind at their backs and others against them, the answer is not in the game. It is in the founding. The left and the right are two ways of answering that question, and neither is complete. The deepest politics is not the contest between them. It is the question they both ask, in different accents: who laid this field, and on what terms may it be laid again?

Key idea. The deepest politics is one question asked in two accents: who laid this field, and on what terms may it be laid again?